

TidyTuesday Week 31

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1 Weekly Summary

AI-Generated Content

The summary below was written by Claude (Anthropic) from that week's regression outputs and series descriptions. It has not been reviewed or fact-checked by a human, and should be read as an automated, informal recap – not analysis.

This week was, if I'm being honest, a bit of a slow news week for the random-correlation industrial complex. We had exactly one matchup to gawk at, and it was a doozy of a pairing: the World Pandemic Uncertainty Index for New Zealand versus Total Private Construction Spending on Communication infrastructure in the United States. Because nothing says "these two things obviously belong in a scatterplot together" like Kiwi pandemic anxiety and American telecom groundbreaking budgets. Truly the crossover event no one requested.

Let me walk you through the white-knuckle drama. In the raw regression, we got a p-value of 0.32, which in the world of statistical significance is roughly the equivalent of showing up to a marathon, tying your shoes, and then going back home. The R-squared clocked in at a heart-stopping 0.008, meaning this relationship explains a proud 0.8 percent of what's going on. Frame it. Put it on the fridge. For once, the raw regression didn't even bother pretending there was a shared trend to hide behind – it just shrugged and gave up on stage, no theatrics required.

And then, the detrended version, our usual mirage-buster, arrived to strip out the trends and find the "real" relationship underneath. What it found underneath was: nothing, still. P-value of 0.45, R-squared of 0.004, a coefficient that flipped sign like it couldn't decide whether it even wanted to be here. So this is that rare, almost refreshing case where there was no trend-mirage to dunk on, because there was no mirage, no oasis, no relationship, and arguably no point. Both regressions agree, in perfect harmony, that these two series have never met and never will.

As always, the mandatory reminder: these are randomly paired economic series flung together by a script for my own amusement, and I am making exactly zero causal or serious statistical claims. Spurious correlation is the house specialty here, and this week we didn't even get a spurious correlation – we got an honest, upstanding pair of series with the decency to have nothing to do with each other. Cherish it. Next week the random number generator will surely find us two things that "line up" and send us all spiraling again.

2 Date: 2026-07-27

Series ID: WUPINZL

This series is titled World Pandemic Uncertainty Index for New Zealand and has a frequency of Quarterly. The units are Index and the seasonal adjustment is Not Seasonally Adjusted. The observation start date is 1996-01-01 and the observation end date is 2026-01-01. The popularity of this series is 1.

Series ID: PRCMUCON

This series is titled Total Private Construction Spending: Communication in the United States and has a frequency of Monthly. The units are Millions of Dollars and the seasonal adjustment is Not Seasonally Adjusted. The observation start date is 1993-01-01 and the observation end date is 2026-05-01. The popularity of this series is 1.

2.1 Raw Regression

Regresses the two series against each other directly. A significant result here can come just as easily from both series sharing a long-run trend as from any real relationship.

Dep. Variable:	value_fred_PRCMUCON	R-squared:	0.008			
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	-0.000			
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	0.9862			
Date:	Mon, 27 Jul 2026	Prob (F-statistic):	0.323			
Time:	14:06:59	Log-Likelihood:	-897.76			
No. Observations:	121	AIC:	1800.			
Df Residuals:	119	BIC:	1805.			
Df Model:	1					
Covariance Type:	nonrobust					
	coef	std err	t	P> t 	[0.025	0.975]
const	1632.8538	37.497	43.547	0.000	1558.607	1707.101
value_fred_WUPINZL	10.4150	10.487	0.993	0.323	-10.351	31.181
Omnibus:	3.754	Durbin-Watson:	0.365			
Prob(Omnibus):	0.153	Jarque-Bera (JB):	2.215			
Skew:	0.059	Prob(JB):	0.330			
Kurtosis:	2.348	Cond. No.	3.63			

Notes:

[1] Standard Errors assume that the covariance matrix of the errors is correctly specified.

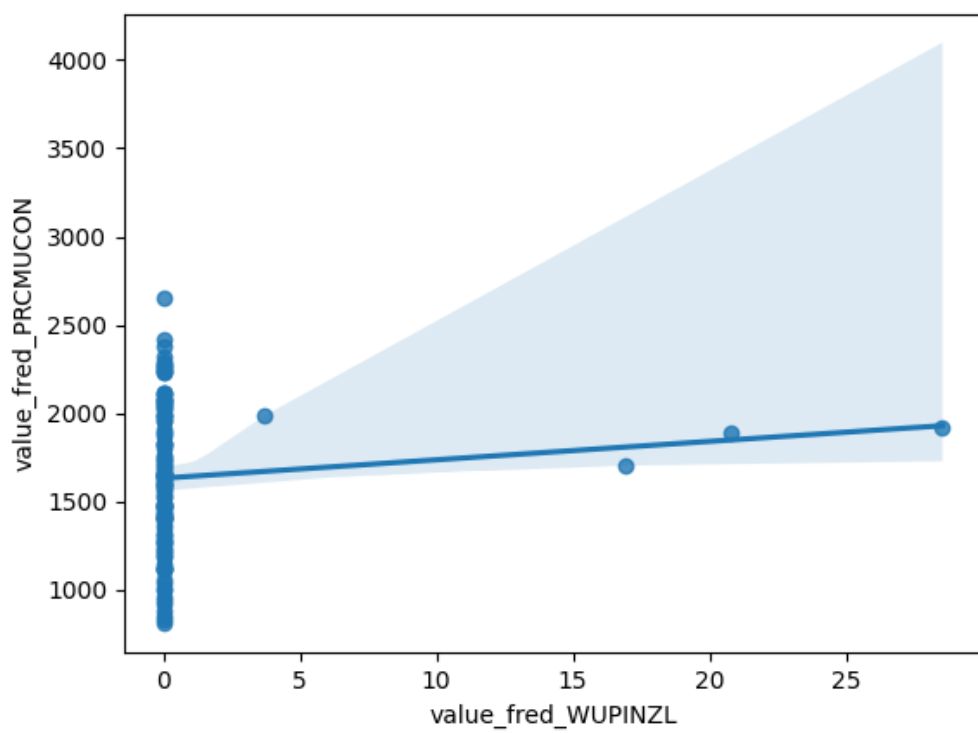


Figure 1: Raw Regression Plot for 2026-07-27

2.2 Detrended Regression

Regresses the residuals of each series after removing its own linear time trend, so a shared trend can no longer drive the result on its own. A relationship that stays significant here is better evidence of a genuine link between the two series.

Dep. Variable:	value_fred_PRCMUCON_detrended	R-squared:	0.005
Model:	OLS	Adj. R-squared:	-0.004
Method:	Least Squares	F-statistic:	0.5697
Date:	Mon, 27 Jul 2026	Prob (F-statistic):	0.452
Time:	14:06:59	Log-Likelihood:	-858.73
No. Observations:	121	AIC:	1721.
Df Residuals:	119	BIC:	1727.
Df Model:	1		
Covariance Type:	nonrobust		

	coef	std err	t	P> t	[0.025	0.975]
const	1.119e-11	26.801	4.17e-13	1.000	-53.069	53.069
value_fred_WUPINZL_detrended	-5.8542	7.756	-0.755	0.452	-21.212	9.503

Omnibus:	14.526	Durbin-Watson:	0.687
Prob(Omnibus):	0.001	Jarque-Bera (JB):	17.629
Skew:	0.701	Prob(JB):	0.000149
Kurtosis:	4.238	Cond. No.	3.46

Notes:

[1] Standard Errors assume that the covariance matrix of the errors is correctly specified.

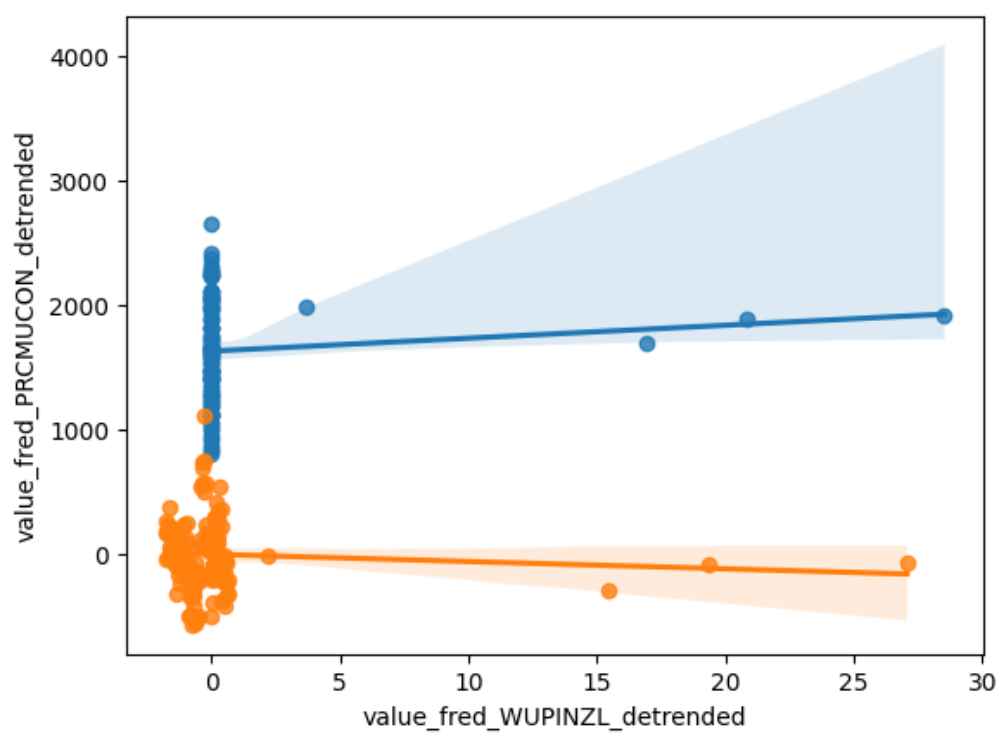


Figure 2: Detrended Regression Plot for 2026-07-27